**Draft for the applicant. Delete this box before filing.** This is a draft description for an Australian provisional patent application, prepared without a patent attorney. Check every statement is true of what you have actually designed, add anything you have learned from building it, and consider having a registered patent attorney review it. A provisional does not need claims.

# PADDLE WITH SURFACE WEAR INDICIA

Provisional patent specification

Applicant and inventor: Aaron Steele

## FIELD

This invention relates to wear indicators for the textured hitting faces of paddles and rackets.

## BACKGROUND

Paddles for pickleball and similar sports have a hitting face with a rough texture that imparts spin. The texture is worn away by ball impact. The loss is gradual and hard to see, and the player has no objective indication of it short of comparison with an unused paddle.

## SUMMARY OF THE INVENTION

In one aspect the invention provides: a paddle having a hitting face with a textured surface of peaks and valleys, and wear indicia comprising a marking material applied substantially only to the peaks within a first region of the face that is subject to ball impact. Abrasion of the peaks removes the marking material, so that visible fading of the indicia corresponds to loss of surface roughness.

## BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWING

Figure 1 shows a paddle with a ring of indicia around the hitting zone, shown faded, and a row of reference indicia near the handle, shown at full strength.

## DETAILED DESCRIPTION

The marking material is applied after the texture is formed, by a roller, pad or screen that contacts only the high points of the texture, so that the valleys remain unmarked. The marking is thin enough not to alter the measured roughness of the face.

Reference indicia of the same marking material are applied in a second region of the face that is not subject to ball impact, such as adjacent the throat or handle. The player compares the first region

with the second. Equal brightness indicates an unworn face. Fading in the first region relative to the second indicates wear.

The indicia may be discrete dots arranged around the centre of the face, or may form part of the graphics of the paddle.

**VARIATIONS**

The following variations are within the scope of the invention, alone or in combination:

1. Graded indicia of two or more colours or thicknesses that disappear at different degrees of wear.
2. Indicia applied to a replaceable face sheet.
3. Use on padel rackets, table tennis rubbers and other textured striking faces.
4. Reference indicia protected beneath an edge guard or clear cover.

The embodiments described are examples only. Features of one embodiment may be combined with features of another.

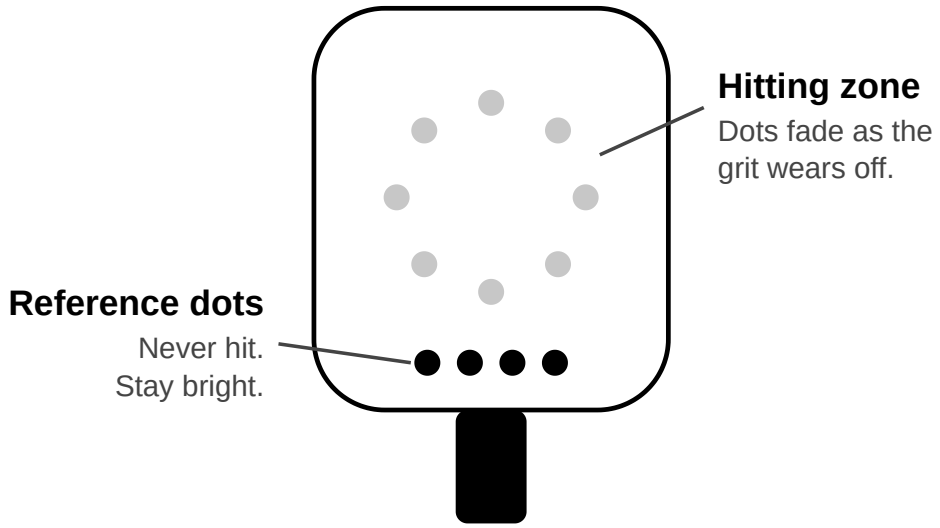



**Figure 1**